

<https://goodauthority.org/news/heres-new-evidence-on-american-support-for-political-violence/>

## Here's new evidence on American support for political violence

Many Americans will support aggression or even violence against their “most hated actor.”

JOHN SIDES — MARCH 27, 2026



Trump supporters attempt to breach the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021, seeking to overturn the 2020 election (cc) Tyler Merbler, via Flickr.

### Introduction:

- Set the stage (what is political violence, why is it important to know more about it) -> for you: war in Crimea, hypotheses you will be evaluating
- Describe the data (they do this very elegantly here: you finish reading the intro, you know what the data is about (what's a row, what are the columns, where does it come from), without them every going into a column-by-column description. -> for you: the two surveys from the Levada Center

Imagine you were asked this question: “Thinking about American politics today, what one person do you think is causing the most harm to America?”

Then, you were asked whether you support or oppose each of the following actions toward that person:

- Kill [actor]
- Hit [actor] with a car
- Throw rocks and bottles at [actor]
- Punch [actor] in the face
- Throw a brick through [actor's] window
- Protest outside [actor's] home while openly carrying weapons
- Send a package to [actor's] office that looks like a bomb
- Send threatening messages to [actor]
- Publicly share information about [actor's] whereabouts
- Curse in [actor's] face

You could choose anything from “strongly support” to “strongly oppose” on a five-category scale, where the middle category is “neither support nor oppose.”

This measure of support for political aggression or violence comes from a [newly published article](#) by Scott Clifford, Lucia Lopez, and Lucas Lothamer. Careful readers of this newsletter may remember an [earlier edition](#) in which I discussed the challenges of measuring support for political violence. (See also this [newly published review](#) by two scholars, Nathan Kalmoe and Lilliana Mason, who have studied this topic extensively.)

There are a few challenges that this new measure – the “most harmful actor” measure – seeks to address. One is that other measures can have relatively ambiguous or generic targets, like whether you support violence against “members of the other side” or the “government.” Another is that measures are sometimes vague about what exactly “violence” means. Measures also vary in whether they specify the other party as the target.

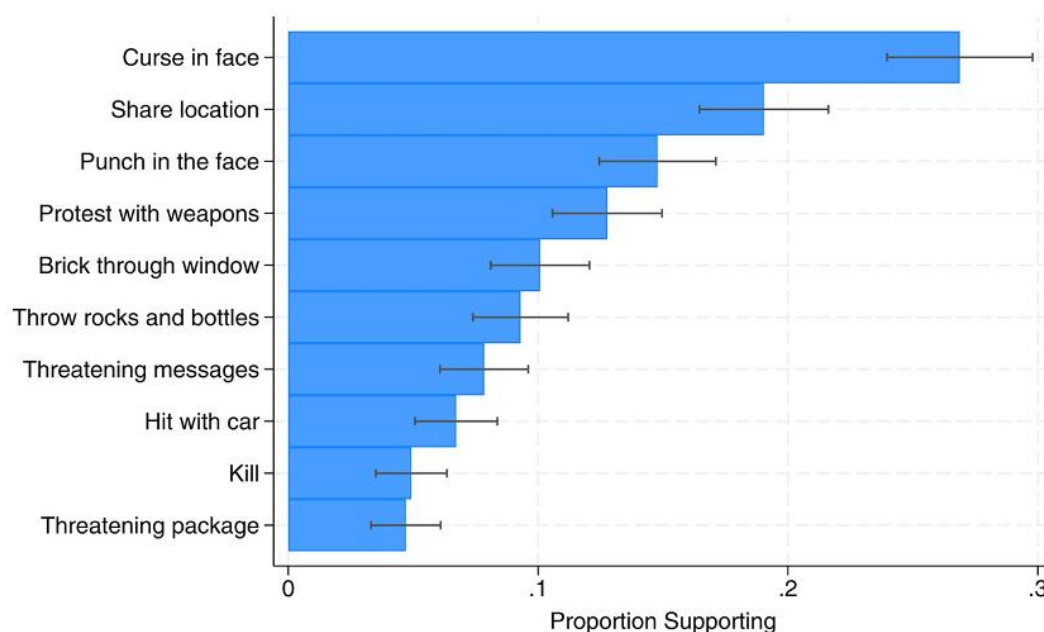
The new measure builds on an idea from the measurement of political tolerance: In terms of support for civil liberties, it is useful to know whether people will extend liberties even to groups that they oppose. In the [tolerance literature](#), a prominent measure asks people for their “least-liked group” and then asks whether they would let this group, say, publicly march in their community.

**Finding 1 - for you: a figure that supports or invalidates the main hypothesis (people watching more news approve of Putin more, or increase their approval more after annexation):**

Here’s what Clifford and colleagues find. First, when asked this question in February 2024, the vast majority of people named either then-President Joe Biden (46%) or Donald Trump (46%). There is probably a separate paper to be written on how and why people center so readily on the president.

See how the figure is introduced very nicely in the text; also, it has confidence intervals -> was constructed using a regression.

Here is the proportion of people supporting political aggression or violence against the person they named:



**They then use the figure to tell a story**

There is little support for several of these acts. A larger fraction would support punching the person in the face, sharing the person’s location, or cursing at this person. Overall, about 30% of people reject all of these acts – that is, they score at the lowest possible value on a scale built from these measures.

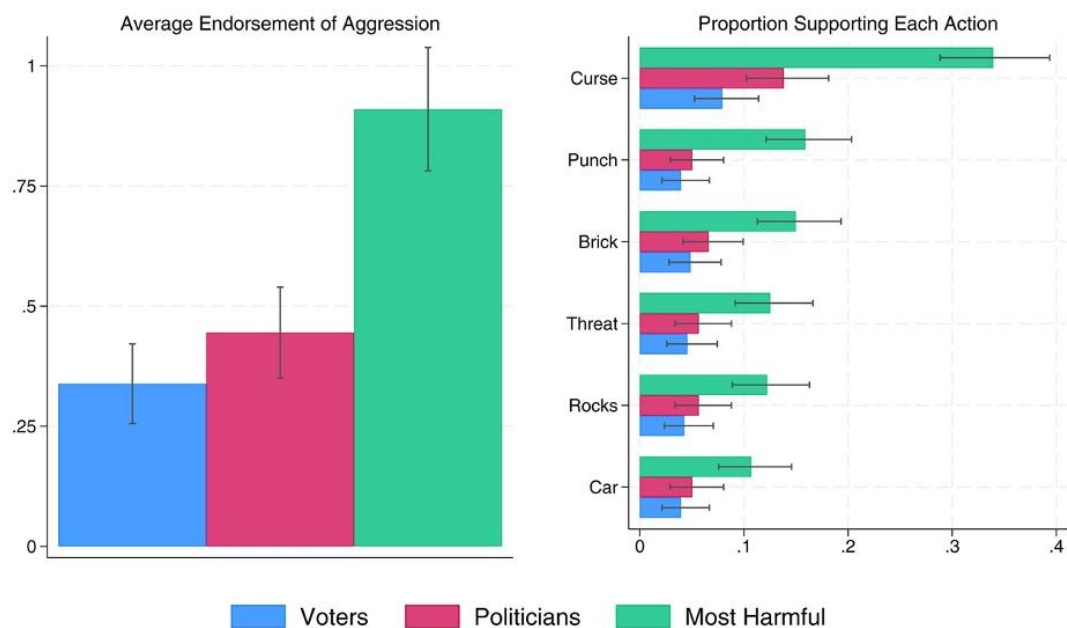
This 30% figure is much higher than the equivalent figure on a standard measure of partisan political violence. People appear more likely to reject partisan violence (e.g., when answering questions like “When (if ever) is it OK for [in-partisans] to send physical threats and intimidating messages to [out-party] leaders?”) than they are to reject violence against this most harmful figure.

In other words, as the authors note, there may be something of a “principle-implementation gap”: Some people will reject partisan political violence in the abstract but endorse it when it comes to the person they think is harming America.

Finding 2 - for you: you decide whether you want to keep talking about the main hypothesis or start talking about your own hypotheses. (you should add another figure)

#### Methods they used

This becomes especially clear in a follow-up experiment. Clifford and colleagues asked about support for aggressive or violent acts but varied the target: an ordinary person in the opposite party, an unnamed leader in the opposite party, or the person that people considered most harmful. Here are those results:



Again, they comment the figure to further their story (here, the story is quite simple, and the article is so well written that they don't need to say much; it's all self-evident because they did a good job at explaining what was going on before)

You can see how much more often participants endorse aggression or violence when they are thinking about this “most harmful” person (the green bars).

#### Discussion about the limitations of the study

- their study has no problems with causality, since it's an experiment, so they don't discuss this problem. It has other problems, those are discussed)
- for you: discuss causality (I expect a more in-depth discussion than theirs). You can show DAGs, but you don't have to. Do it only if you think it would help the reader understand what you're saying.

Now, we have to be cautious in interpreting survey-based measures of support for political violence. As [previous research](#) and Clifford and colleagues find, endorsement of political violence is more prevalent among survey respondents who appear to be paying less attention to the survey or responding insincerely. This problem is not as prevalent in this “most harmful person” measure as it is in some other measures of political violence, but it's still real.

## Conclusion

Nevertheless, I think this way of measuring support for political violence helps us understand something important. In my [earlier newsletter](#) on this topic, I noted that people appear to be more willing to endorse specific acts of political violence (like the January 6th attack) even if they appear to reject violence in general. This is another example of the principle-implementation gap.

If the “most harmful actor” measure is any indication, we should expect this gap to appear and reappear. It will be an ongoing test of whether people’s abstract opposition to political violence is set aside when the target is someone they fear.